Why Excel Breaks Your CSV Files: A Practical Checklist

Leading zeros, long IDs, dates and delimiters

The problem

A CSV is plain text. Excel guesses what each cell means when it opens the file, and saving afterwards writes the guess back. The result: files that look fine but import wrongly somewhere else.

1. Leading zeros disappear

A code such as 00123 is read as the number 123. Zip codes, SKUs and product codes are common victims. Fix: import the column as Text, or use a tool that writes the file as .xlsx with the value kept as text.

2. Long IDs lose digits

Excel stores numbers with about 15 significant digits. A 20-digit ID is rounded and shown as 1.23457E+19. Once saved, the original digits are gone for good. Always check long numeric IDs before and after.

3. Values that look like numbers or dates

1E5 becomes 100000. 3-4 can become 3 April. Gene names, part numbers and ranges are often damaged this way.

4. Day/month ambiguity

04/05/2026 is 4 May in some countries and 5 April in others. A file with only ambiguous dates cannot be fixed automatically. Check whether any date has a day above 12, and agree on one format with whoever receives the file.

5. Delimiters and encoding

Some systems expect commas, others semicolons or tabs. If accented characters show as odd symbols, the encoding (UTF-8 versus a legacy code page) is wrong. Excel on one computer may use a different delimiter than on another.

6. Hidden characters

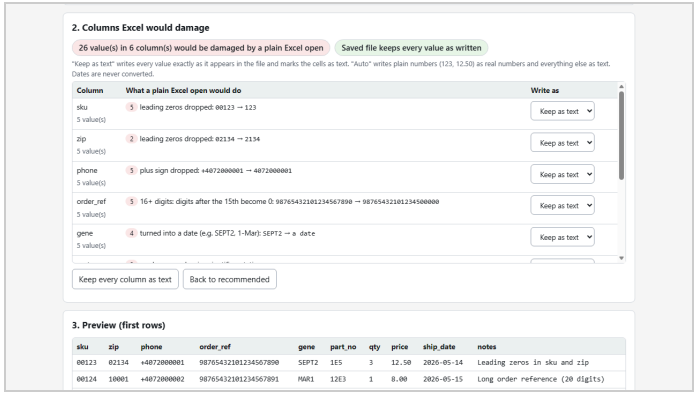
Non-breaking spaces, zero-width characters and tabs make two codes that look identical fail to match in a lookup. Search for them when a lookup should work and does not.

7. Repeat the same cleanup

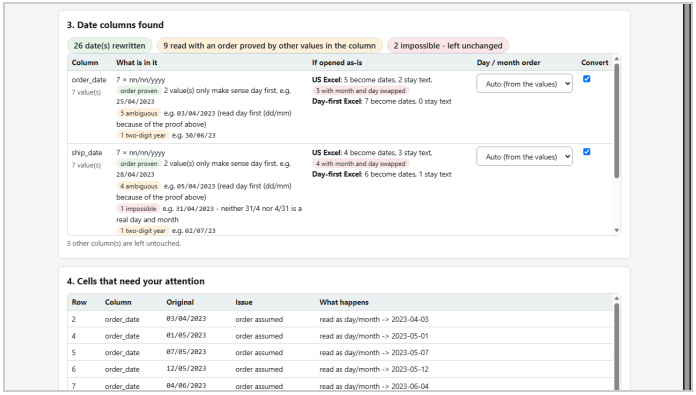
If you receive the same export every week, write the steps down once: column order, formats, checks. Doing it by hand each time is how mistakes return.

What it looks like

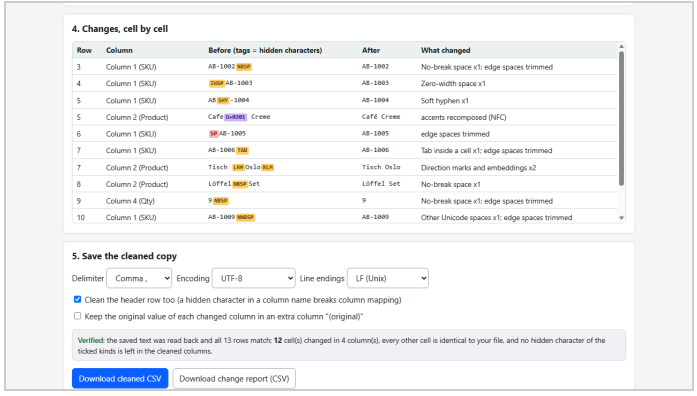
Screenshots from the tools, with sample data. Click a caption to open the product page.



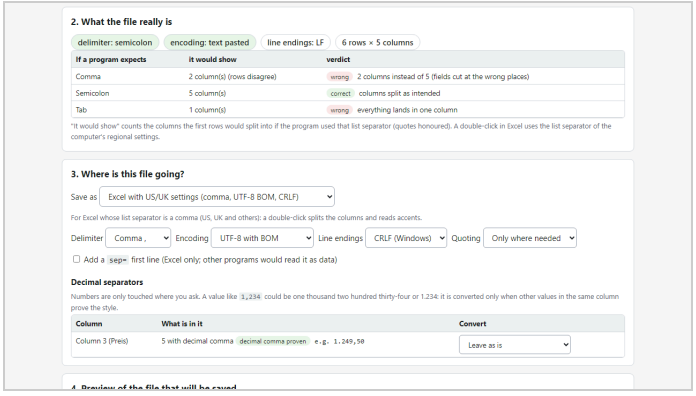
CSV ID Keeper



CSV Date Fit



CSV Ghost Chars



CSV Dialect Switch

> Offline browser tools that handle these cases: CSV ID Keeper, CSV Date Fit, CSV Dialect Switch, CSV Ghost Chars and CSV Profile Runner.
> All run offline in your browser. All products and prices: https://asecrier.gumroad.com